to follow as soon as the visit got over, which was commencing the very next day. We got the news of his passing while Veena was still at Bangkok, and while I was waiting on the tarmac at Naypyitaw to receive the VP and his entourage. It was a big blow to us. He had always been there, especially when I was away on my numerous field postings, and the girls loved playing with him.

In mid-2009, I had gone to the harbour to receive two of our Indian Navy ships that had come for a port call. Lined up on the jetty leading to where our ships were berthed were lines and lines of tipper trucks and dozers that China had provided in response to the MA's request. When I returned to the embassy, I immediately called the MIFD to check on the status of our proposal. As expected, the proposal had got caught up in red tape. Who would fund the project; MEA, since it was in a foreign country or MoD, since the request had come through defence channels? The civil firms who had to produce the equipment would not start the production until a firm order was placed with them, which was fair enough. In order to place an order though, a government sanction letter (GSL) was required, which was not forthcoming as the source of funding was undecided. Even if the GSL were to be given the very same day, the civil firms had a lead time of eighteen to twenty-four months, since they had other orders to fulfil. At this rate, nothing would materialize until end-2010 or mid-2011, by which time I would have returned to India. This was just not acceptable to me.

I kept monitoring the case but by early 2010, it was nowhere near the GSL stage. In March of that year, I went on leave and met everyone handling the case in both the MEA and MoD. Gen Deepak Kapoor was the COAS then, and he had visited Myanmar in 2009 on an official visit. During the visit,

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